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1 secondary sources, *orlando*

1.1 Benzel, Kathryn N.

"Reading readers in Virginia Woolf's *Orlando: A Biography*." **Style**, Summer 1994, p. 169+. **Academic OneFile**, go.galegroup.com.ezproxy.gc.cuny.edu/ps/i.do?p=AONE\sw=

Benzel application to the space break: Benzel argues that the narrator writes in a way that requires the reader's input. There are explicit moments, like the space break. Here, the narrator is being clear about the work of the author and of the reader. It is up to the author to write, and the reader to read. Readers are part of the creation of meaning. They incorporate their own creative powers, like the writer. The reader works like the writer to create meaning by what is there, or isn't there. Which is what the space break shows us. So this is one level of application between reader and writer. There's another application on a thematic level for *Orlando's* character. We cannot truly know *Orlando's* character, we only know what the biographer tells us, and the biographer is also limited by her perspective. A lot of this is guesswork. Speculation, based off of what isn't there. The blank space therefore also represents what we do not get of *Orlando*. The absence of evidence, which we have to fill in.

Benzel identifies the collaborative nature of reading that Woolf requires by asking her readers to recognize the "plurality in the text through his/her own multilevel reading" In *Orlando: A Biography*, Virginia Woolf experiments with both biographical and fictional conventions in order to engage the readers in the creation of the text's meaning. In *Orlando* Woolf develops a narrative environment that encourages the writer and reader to share the

aesthetic experience in this text. This type of reading posits relational and alternative ways to discovering about the world in the text; readers are asked to "refresh and exercise

their

own creative powers" in order "to make use of all that the novelist—the great artist—gives

them

." By analyzing this cooperative interaction, the text is revealed as a territory, often a narrative playground, in which reader creates and recreates an aesthetics of reading.

"The cooperative process between reader and writer in *Orlando* is analogous to the characterization of *Orlando*: like the biographer struggling to characterize the subject, we as readers struggle to create our place in this text. The writer, the narrator-biographer, and reader must work to overcome the constraints of narrative conventions in order to construct a "real self," a self that creates a reality in and of the text. From this relationship between writer and reader, a Woolfian aesthetic emerges, an aesthetic that is collaborative, contextual, and compelling. " "The shared aesthetic experience, I believe, motivates Woolf in *Orlando* as she attempts to define and redefine the reader's role as participant creating the biographical characterization of *Orlando*."

"Rabinowitz's and Phelan's rhetorical approaches to audience clarify Woolf's notion of the reader's double perspective as the reader experiences both the mimetic illusion of the story and its manner of presentation. By engaging with the text on these two levels, the reader experiences reading as a creative activity, an aesthetic experience in the context of this particular text. While we read, we seek out textual cues that reinforce the mimetic illusion, but the very act of seeking out such cues focuses our synthetic reading. The consequent tension between the narrative reader (looking for representation) and the authorial reader (recognizing the text's discourse) enriches the aesthetic experience by engaging the reader with the text's multiplicity. This aesthetic is an act of interpretation in the sense of Roland Barthes's notion of interpretation: "To interpret a text is . . . to appreciate what plural constitutes it" (5; Barthes's emphasis). By concentrating our attentions both on the character of *Orlando* and on the construction of *Orlando*'s character, Woolf creates a double-visioned reader, a reader who realizes the plurality in the text through his/her own multilevel reading."

"The distance between the narrative and authorial readings allows the reader to play with the characterization of *Orlando*'s sexuality in order to

reconstruct an image of multiplicity that works within the text.”

1.2 Berman, J.

“Is the Trans in Transnational the Trans in Transgender?" **Modernism/modernity**, vol. 24 no. 2, 2017, pp. 217-244. **Project MUSE**, [<https://doi.org/10.1353/mod.2017.0019>](<http://doi.org/10.1353/mod.2017.0019>)

“Woolf’s novel, like other twentieth-century narratives, demands to be read as what I call a "trans" text, one that challenges prevailing assumptions about national belonging and scenes of reading, asking to be situated in the context of transnational modernism or twentieth-century "world literature" at the same time as it raises the question of gender and sexual identity as a constitutive dimension of those critical categories.[6](<https://muse-jhu-edu.ezproxy.gc.cuny.edu/article/658469#f6>) This kind of a "trans" text challenges the normative dimensions of regimes of nationality and disrupts the systems of embodied identity that undergird them. It pushes us to recognize that any discussion of transnational or world literature must also attend to the assumptions of embodiment and gender identity that are attached to the concept of the nation” (218).

“Reading the transnational situation as also intrinsically transgender disrupts the determinative power of both the sexed body and its "home" geography, thereby also challenging the Orientalism of the novel’s Turkish episodes and the seeming solidity of categories of gender identity once Orlando arrives back on English soil” (218).

“Under this rubric, a transnational **and** transgender approach to **Orlando** would not simply juxtapose male and female Orlando, or Orlando in Turkey with Orlando returned to England, but would rather explore the challenge to embodied normative nationality that emerges throughout the middle sections of the book, making national belonging both what Orlando longs for from the hills of Turkey and what her transformative experience in Turkey forever undoes. Throughout the novel, as the narrator claims, Orlando’s sex may often be the "very opposite" from "what . . . is above" (139). From its troubling first pages, this transgendered status also lies at the heart of the novel’s critique of empire, in which bodies must be identifiably marked, categorized, and placed in hierarchies. Reading this novel under the rubric of the oppositional prefix "trans" thus highlights the extent to which Orlando’s sex change in Turkey is also—and always—a challenge to the embodiment of nationality and empire, and invites us to recognize the importance of this confluence in other texts, both from the early decades of the twentieth century and beyond” (221).

“In much contemporary transgender theory, the prefix "trans" has come to stand not for gender or sexual identities that have moved from one side of a binary field to the other, but rather for "anything that disrupts, denaturalizes, rearticulates and makes visible" the links we assume to exist between a sexual body and the social roles it is expected to play” (222).

“Having no category for a transgender subject, the nation must domesticate Orlando by naming her as immutably female, and assigning her the diminished rights and opportunities of women in late-Victorian England: "The lawsuits are settled. . . . My sex . . . is pronounced indisputably, and beyond the shadow of a doubt. . . . Female. The estates which are now desequestrated in perpetuity descend and are tailed and entailed upon the heirs male of my body" (*Orlando*, 186–87). Orlando’s ultimate loss, as a woman, of the right to inherit demonstrates not only women’s political and economic poverty within the Victorian gender system, but also the degree to which the state depends on this binary system as a basis for assigning citizenship roles, policing its borders, and determining who has legal standing to inherit, hold property, or sue for redress. . . . In other words, despite Orlando’s seeming reinscription into national norms of femininity, attending to her trans status shows how, in the novel, a transgender identity produces a kind of internal exile and generates transnational critique” (227).

“Indeed, personhood, as it is understood in post-Enlightenment Western legal systems and in such documents as the United Nations’ Universal Declaration of Human Rights (1948), does not mark the "human as such." Rather, it constructs "a person as a member of a people or nation—a particular kind of human activated as a legal and moral unit" (Slaughter, *Human Rights, Inc.*, 58). The "person" therefore becomes embodied as a normative entity with specific rights, responsibilities, and duties under existing social, cultural, moral, and juridical systems and remains inscribed within—and often subjected to—existing hierarchies of gender, power, and value (Spade, *Normal Life*, 30, 37). By implication, the non-conforming "human" risks losing access to "human rights."” (229-230).

“By ruminating on the potential disconnection between clothing and embodiment, Woolf not only mobilizes a familiar Orientalist trope but also and perhaps more importantly demonstrates that we never have "unmediated access" to "the materiality of the body" nor do we ever know it with certainty (Salamon, *Assuming a Body*, 1). As in many other moments in Woolf’s text, this scene shows us that lurking beneath every clothed, draped, cloaked, hatted, or turbaned body—whether in East or West—lies the perpetual disjuncture between embodiment and the biopolitics of gendered, and racialized, national identity. . . .). While the gender-neutral Turkish trousers

had "distract

ed

her" from the question of her sex, English garb insists upon it, and demands that she change clothes as she vacillates among gender identities, slipping in and out of womanhood during the succeeding pages (113)" (234).

"Understanding the variety of relationships between these terms prevents us from mistakenly viewing the transnational as a purely spatial or political attitude that can be put on or taken off without affecting other more "core" aspects of identity or, on the other hand, understanding transgender identity as a personal or biological matter, essential and separate from the historical and political concerns of nationality, identity, or allegiance. . . I would argue that Woolf reaches for Orientalist tropes in **Orlando** not because of her fantasies about Turkey or the gypsies (which she may well have harbored) but because she rightly recognized that English civic discourses about gender and nationality allowed no room for narratives of transgression or change on her home turf" (235).

1.3 Burns, Christy L.

"Re-Dressing Feminist Identities: Tensions between Essential and Constructed Selves in Virginia Woolf's *Orlando*." **Twentieth Century Literature**, vol. 40, no. 3, 1994, pp. 342–364. **JSTOR**, www.jstor.org/stable/441560.

"As desire for identification draws Woolf toward the genre of biographical fiction, the need for differentiation following upon such a mimetic project propels her back into parody.² If the text is "true to" Sackville-West's personal history, the novel is still quite unfaithful to the genre of biography. How can one be both faithful to facts and unfaithful and tell more of the truth without exactly telling it the same?" (342).

"In her novel truth is destabilized and turns into parody through an emphasis on period fashions, cross-dressing, and undressing of "essential"" (343).

"This question of whether some innate human essence can surmount historical effects or whether the only "essence" we know as personality is fully shaped by the world around one—this problem is comically re-figured by Woolf as the question of whether the clothes "make the (wo)man."" (343).

"I do not aim to treat *Orlando* as a mirror to any single vision of contemporary feminism, so much as to mark it as a historically significant text that informatively examines the tensions between notions of essential personal identity and contextually re-defined subjectivity, tensions that are repli-

cated in contemporary debates between essentialist and post-structuralist feminists" (344).

Parodying different kinds of biography: Lytton Strachey's psychoanalytic method (influenced by Freud) and Leslie Stephen's essentialist method (influenced by the Positivists). Questions of social constructedness versus essential selfhood. "Orlando was the novel that allowed her to chart the tension between these two contradictory beliefs" (345).

"The questioning of identity in *Orlando* raises issues that are of returning importance to feminism. How much of the self, Woolf asks, is unchangeably and essentially our own? How solid a space does one have for resistance to social demands for conformity? Does the "spirit of an age" weigh upon the sexes differently? And how does one's adaptation or resistance to society affect one's writing? If such questions are implicitly structuring the narrative drama of *Orlando*, they are explicitly posed in Woolf's feminist essays, most notably in *A Room Of One's Own*" (346).

"*Orlando*'s sex change parodies the philosophical search for bare, naked, essential truths. And it is no coincidence that a parodic text will unravel any fantasy of pure and perfect mimetic reference... In this scene such classic motifs as unveiling and nakedness are re-organized around questions of sexuality, and what is "revealed" or "unveiled," the "truth" of *Orlando*'s sex-that he is a she-points only to the essential instability of essence, the reversibility inscribed within the "truth". What is essential here is to be without an essence. What is revealed is the reversibility of sex" (350).

"The biographer struggles to write the "naked truth" about *Orlando*, but the revelation of his sex change tells us little. Likewise, *Orlando* later gets embroiled in the struggle to "say what one means and leave it." What she finds in trying to abandon metaphor, however, is that simple statements get no closer to the truth" (352).

"I do believe that the form of parody that Butler describes-one that presses toward heterogeneous mixtures of the norm and the contra-normal-carries with it the politics she describes. Her model offers parody and cross-dressing, in particular, as acts that cross boundaries and allow one to perform subjectivity in a dialogue with social expectations for conformity-to resist without fully breaking with, to remain politically active within the system without conforming to it" (356).

"I point toward this close relation between "the self" and biography that constructs the self through language in order to emphasize the ways in which *Orlando*'s surviving question-that of who *Orlando* is-and Woolf's genre, parodic biography, are integrally related. I would like to suggest through a reading of *Orlando* that notions of the self are intricately linked to writing

for Woolf, and that the essence of a word functions just like the essence of a person, clothed in social conventions and full of indeterminacy' (357).

1.4 Channing, Jill.

"Magical realism and gender variability in Orlando." **Virginia Woolf Miscellany**, no. 67, 2005, p. 11+. **Literature Resource Center**, go.galegroup.com.ezproxy.gc.cuny.edu/p

"Woolf would probably not have known of the term "magical realism"; however, like all magical realist novels, Orlando disrupts modern realist narrative expectations, destabilizes normative oppositions, blurs and transgresses boundaries, is an act of subversion, and most importantly, I believe, creates a space for diversity. In Orlando, not only is Woolf writing a prototype of a magical realist text that is subversive and creates a space for diversity, sexual diversity specifically, she is also using this genre to critique British cultural views of sexuality" (11).

"While Orlando is subversive in form and content, Woolf would not have been able to overtly express her ideas about gender and sexuality except through her experimental use of magical realism. After seeing works of authors such as James Joyce and D. H. Lawrence being tried for obscenity and consequently being censored, Woolf probably anticipated that she should disguise her representations of the fluidity of sexuality in order to protect her work from censorship" (11).

"The touchstone of magical realist work is the "irreducible element"... "The central magical event in Orlando—although not the only magical irreducible event—is Orlando's changing from a man into a woman. There is no explanation offered for the sex change, and Orlando does not appear to be concerned by the event" (11-12).

"Another significant characteristic of magical realism, according to Faris, is "historical anchoring" often expressed by "a character

who

experiences historical forces bodily" (Ordinary 16). The spirit of the age, an irreducible element itself, has power over Orlando that she sometimes resists but never can completely ignore" (12). "Presenting societal forces as "the spirit of the age" allows Woolf to critique compulsory heterosexuality by presenting it as a magical force that gives Orlando no choice" (12).

"The third element of magical realism outlined by Faris is the presence of unsettling doubts. Faris explains it thus: "Before categorizing the irreducible element as irreducible, the reader may hesitate between two contradictory understandings of events, and hence experience some unsettling doubts" (17).

Most of these unsettling doubts are caused by the reader's confrontation with magic, and the biographer provides no definite explanations for these magical occurrences. However, the narrator offers some possibilities when s/he cannot explain something that has happened" (12).

"Hesitations could also be caused by the fourth characteristic Faris uses to define magical realism, which is the "near-merging of two realms" (Ordinary 21). Orlando blurs the world as experienced by men and women. These two realms come close to merging since although Orlando changes sexes, s/he remained "fundamentally the same" (237)... Her merging and reemerging from the worlds as experienced by men and women allows Orlando to critique especially how men stereotypically view women. Orlando finds that women have desires just as men and that they, contrary to what men think, are capable of feeling for their own sex" (12-13).

"Magical realism allows Woolf to transcend absolutes, binary oppositions, and genre-defined boundaries of literature as well as socially-defined boundaries of sexuality to create a character who is not simply a bisexual and dynamic character, Orlando, but to create a character who is multisexual" (13).

1.5 de Gay, Jane.

"Virginia Woolf's feminist historiography in *Orlando*." Critical Survey, vol. 19, no. 1, 2007, p. 62+. Literature Resource Center, go.galegroup.com/ps/i.do?p=GLS&sw=w&u=cuny

"Within her fantastic narrative and through her protagonist, a writer who lives for 350 years and changes sexes part-way through, Woolf traces the changing conditions for writers, and reflects upon the effect of gender on their experiences. Furthermore, by incorporating parodies of literary and social history and biography into *Orlando* Woolf also critiques scholarly apparati for viewing the past, thus developing her ideas about the writing and rewriting of history. This article will demonstrate that Woolf alludes and responds to specific debates about the form literary history should take; the significance of the past to the present; and the importance of the imagination in engaging with the past" (63).

Woolf satirizes the "spirit of the age", periodization, Ruskin, Stephen.

"Orlando, therefore, enacts the imaginative search to rediscover lost origins which Woolf had advocated in *A Room of One's Own*, by using Orlando's long life to trace a heritage for a twentieth-century woman writer back to the Renaissance. In satirizing the methods of Stephen and Ruskin, she rejected Victorian patriarchal metanarratives, which had left out the history of women writers and had attempted to package the past in ways

which reinforced patriarchal ideologies. Instead she inclines to a school of critics who sought to tap into the past and release its energies, and who used the strategies of fiction to bring history alive and make it live in the present. By placing Woolf's feminist historiography in the tradition of Pater and Lee, we can see why Woolf made her fullest and most sustained attempt to rewrite history in *Orlando* rather than in a nonfictional work: for Woolf, the imagination provided the only satisfactory medium for embracing the lost past" (71).

1.6 Hovey, Jaime.

"'Kissing a Negress in the Dark': Englishness as a Masquerade in Woolf's *Orlando*." *PMLA*, vol. 112, no. 3, 1997, pp. 393–404. **JSTOR**, [www.jstor.org/stable/462948](<http://www.jstor.org/stable/462948>).

"Given the extent to which ideologies of national inclusion depend on equating gender with the performance of heterosexual respectability and equating national affiliation with notions of racial belonging, one might conclude that gender and nationality can operate as essentializing ideologies of identity only if sexuality and race remain nationality's half-hidden or forgotten others" (393).

"Virginia Woolf's *Orlando* (1928) can be read as an ambivalent articulation of English nationalism in the 1920s, an era in which the essentializing imperatives of an Englishness "at once less imperial and more inward-looking, more domestic and more private" (Light 8\) came to preoccupy the English public" (394). "*Orlando* seeks a place of national belonging for the polymorphously sexual, masculine identified white woman" (394).

"Butler argues that gender depends for its intelligibility on the difference it supposedly creates and on exclusions it seeks to hide (Bodies 39). Sexuality and other dimensions of identity, such as nation and race, are seen as performed through gender, and gender is seen as performed through them" (397).

Besides costume, humor also works as a masquerade to subvert traditional gender roles (398).

"From the first page of *Orlando*, the narrator stabilizes Orlando's indeterminate gender by articulating his masculinity within the racialized terms of national identity" (398).

"*Orlando* critiques whiteness and heterosexuality ambivalently and unevenly; it uses racially and sexually "foreign" subjects to explore the ambiguous national and social identity of a queerly gendered white Englishwoman, excluded from the nation by her polymorphous sexuality. Beginning with

an image of a decapitated Moor, Orlando appropriates the exoticized subjects of colonial discourse to create for its protagonist a sexuality that is not bourgeois or heterosexual. However, Orlando's playful but insistent production of white femininity allows the protagonist to pass as respectable and heterosexual by displacing her transgressive sexuality onto racial others, thereby masking Orlando's masculine-identified literary and sexual desires. The "playful" exchange of racial others for sexual tolerance allows the novel both to interrogate and to affirm the national belonging of the queerly gendered Englishwoman. . . " (398).

"Orlando slyly invites readers to unmask the "joking" terms under which femininity is produced—as gender identities are often, if not always, produced—as both an adaptation and a contestation of the constraints of national, racial, and sexual inclusion" (403).

1.7 Knopp, Sherron E.

"If I Saw You Would You Kiss Me?": Sapphism and the Subversiveness of Virginia Woolf's Orlando." **PMLA**, vol. 103, no. 1, 1988, pp. 24–34. **JS-TOR**, www.jstor.org/stable/462459.

"Yet the extent to which Vita and Virginia did love each other—profoundly and, in every sense of the words, erotically and sexually (the frequency or infrequency with which they went to bed is irrelevant)—is something that continues to be resisted, denied, ignored, qualified out of significance, or simply unrecognized, even by the feminist revolution that has enshrined Virginia as its saint. There seems to be an unspoken agreement that whatever else one might call Virginia—asexual, bisexual, androgynous—she was not a "sapphist." (24–25). "The assumption seems to be that lesbian love is only or primarily sexual, that love involving the emotional intimacy of minds and hearts requires a different term" (25).

"But to see just how large and attached to life Orlando is, one must first get the relationship between Virginia and Vita right and then see it in context: what it meant to regard oneself as a lesbian (or, to use the term Virginia and Vita prefer, sapphist) and to engage in lesbian relationships in the 1920s and what it meant to write about one's perceptions and experiences" (25).

Examines the letters for passion and relationship between Vita and Virginia: "Far from being a way to create distance in the relationship, Orlando was a way to heighten intimacy—not a substitute for physical lovemaking but an extension of it" (27).

"But what is the "sexual theme"? Orlando is obviously not about the

sapphic love of Vita and Virginia, even in a disguised way. The hero/heroine loves men and women over the course of four hundred years, but no one of these is the subject. The central relationship is between Orlando and the Biographer, but although Virginia acknowledged the erotic pleasure it gave her to think and write about Vita, there is nothing overtly or even covertly erotic in the relationship between Orlando and the Biographer in the novel. If Orlando has any claim to be regarded as a lesbian novel, it is one of the best kept secrets in literary history, having eluded even those who should be the first to know" (28-29).

"Orlando is not a woman acting "like" a man: Orlando is a man. And a woman. The situation admittedly puts a strain on conventional language and thinking, but there is nothing "unnatural" about it. Orlando takes the "dual personality" Vita described in her diary and transforms the "brutal" side that loved Rosamund and Violet into the romantic passion of a Renaissance nobleman, while the "seraphic," "childlike" side capable of "years of marriage" becomes the Victorian woman who marries Shelmerdine/Harold Nicolson with all due respect for nineteenth-century standards of female behavior" (30).

"Sasha, the Russian Princess, haunts the memory of Orlando the woman as powerfully and pervasively as she dominates the passions of Orlando the man... Even minor female characters like the prostitutes Nell, Prue, Kitty, and Rose (216-22) have a serious dignity not bestowed on more prominent male characters. The anomaly of Orlando's marriage to Shelmerdine, in fact, occasions the clearest acknowledgment of theme in the novel: 'She was married, true; but if one's husband was always sailing round Cape Horn, was it marriage?'" (31-32).

1.8 Micir, Melanie.

"The queer timing of Orlando: a biography." **Virginia Woolf Miscellany**, no. 82, 2012, p. 11+. **Literature Resource Center**, go.galegroup.com.ezproxy.gc.cuny.edu/ps/i.do?pa=1&u=gc&it=r

"The possibility that one might now understand Orlando as only a love story limits Sackville-West's importance as biographical subject and reduces the formal difficulty of Orlando to scarcely more than a set of references to "the love that dare not speak its name," which, once decoded, becomes unworthy of study except as biographical evidence. In this way, one queer reading actually diminishes the larger stakes—both feminist and queer—of the text."

"I want to suggest the expansion of these approaches to Orlando through renewed attention to genre: specifically, to the book's often overlooked sub-

title, "A Biography." Woolf's revision and expansion of biography's generic codes in *Orlando* make it a uniquely important text to revisit in light of contemporary theorizations of queer temporality. In this brief essay, I foreground what I think of as *Orlando*'s queer time in relation to biographical form, and I demonstrate the resonances between Woolf's critique of the generic conventions of biography and contemporary queer critiques of the institutions of what Lee Edelman has called "reproductive futurism." "Queer temporality studies critique understandings of time as a naturalized, internalized, bodily performance of the too easily accepted social scripts that govern our lives, asking us instead to recognize and resist—in our scholarly practices as in our lives—the standard, heteronormative, biologically-driven temporal organization of our world."

"Biography, as a literary genre, is the gatekeeper par excellence of reproductive time, and it is difficult to extract oneself from the normativizing pull of biographical form." "If biographies tell individual life stories, so the modernist critique goes, then there is no reason why all biographies must follow the same deadening, if factually accurate, formal structure." "Modernist biographies, like so many modernist novels, highlight the individual, subjective experience of time in order to dissociate the multiple "lives" of private individuals from the unified "times" of public, historical record. If one of the projects of modernist biography is to represent more than "six or seven selves" in any given individual, then this taxonomy of people-in-time in *Orlando* indicates Woolf's refusal of Victorian biography's insistence upon documented fact and its reliance upon the standard chronology of "every normal human system." In *Orlando*, she demonstrates the power of fiction to stretch understandings of what constitutes the "normal" in biographical writing."

"Disrupting this form is not a merely literary decision; though playfully undertaken, this is not mere play: for Woolf, rupturing the generic conventions of biography is a means of unseating the keystone of normativity itself. I am suggesting that Woolf's questions are still contemporary questions: how can one escape—or at least shift—the weight of standard time, standard expectations, standard lives?" "Woolf may have begun *Orlando*, the first of her biographies, as a joke, but the stakes of her project were quite serious. Should conventional understandings of temporal progression govern the representation of individual lives? Or should the normative milestones of standard time be subordinate to other methods of representing the subject, . . ."

"In *Orlando*, Woolf frees her unconventional subject from the trappings of a conventional, biologically-bound lifetime (and its correspondingly con-

ventional, chronologically-organized biography). Orlando is part of a long history of imaginative and theoretical attempts to set free the human experience from the shackles of standard time. It is part of a genealogy of frustration with normative temporalities. In rejecting and reshaping the formal conventions of standard biography, Orlando shifts the conditions of legibility for the queer life story.”

1.9 Smith, V. L.

"Ransacking the Language": Finding the Missing Goods in Virginia Woolf's Orlando." **Journal of Modern Literature**, vol. 29 no. 4, 2006, pp. 57-75. **Project MUSE**, [<https://doi.org/10.1353/jml.2006.0050>](<http://doi.org/10.1353/jml.2006.0050>) "Ransacking the Language": Finding the Missing Goods in Virginia Woolf's Orlando." **Journal of Modern Literature**, vol. 29 no. 4, 2006, pp. 57-75. **Project MUSE**, [<https://doi.org/10.1353/jml.2006.0050>](<http://doi.org/10.1353/jml.2006.0050>)

“...the fantastic content in the novel is directly linked to the undecidability/impossibility of the form of the novel and of the protagonist. That is, what happens in the novel—the impossible story of the protagonist rather unremarkably changing from a man to woman and living 400 years—and what it thematizes—language’s inability to adequately represent the “thing itself”—mirrors the undecidability of the text—is it a biography, an autobiography, fantasy, etc.—and the impossibility of the form of “woman.” In other words, what is Orlando? Is she a Woman? If so, how can she be represented? In short, the text echoes the difficulty of representation in the difficulty of representing woman for herself, as herself. The consequences of this doubling of/in the text are profound: Woolf re-animates the form of biography, produces a text where Vita can read/see herself, as can Woolf, and enables both women to have compensatory stories of their own. Woolf’s work, then, suggests that a doubleness is needed to produce the self as woman, to represent (her) self” (58).

Oneself represented through the double:

- “In what follows, I move between the real and its representation in order show the something “other” that Woolf builds between. I suggest that Woolf foregrounds the doubleness that is needed to produce the self as woman in language and in culture; that is, Virginia needs Vita to represent herself and vice versa, and this parallels the conundrum of language for women—the **only way to represent oneself is through a doubled otherness**. In other words, if according to

poststructuralists, language is always (at least) one step away from the thing itself, and if woman, according to feminism, occupies the space of object/thing (in culture), then woman is always one step away from herself as well—a twice removed relative of language” (59).

“the novel might be a metaphorical recovery of what Woolf and Sackville-West could not, as women and as lovers, have” (64).

“For Sackville-West, Orlando is a compensation for losses—a kind of mourning for Violet/Sasha, for the loss of Knole. The novel returns these “objects” to Sackville-West and adds the bonus of mirroring her as a magnificent, magical figure wearing a “robe stitched in jewels”... For Woolf, Orlando is a compensation for the loss of Sackville-West, a mourning of her. She gets to keep a “fixed” Sackville-West, a woman who will not betray her, as well as a vision of Sackville-West as a kind of idealized version of herself—a woman who could write, have children, be sexual, be aristocratic, have affairs and do all the things that she felt unable to accomplish. On the other hand, Woolf can criticize her for lacking a necessary something in her writing. In this way, Woolf also critiques herself, identifies and displaces onto another person her own fears about the inadequacy of her writing” (67).

Bemoaning the inadequacy of language

- “If Orlando as a text mitigates a series of losses in the real world through rewriting, it also thematizes within the text how representation or, rather more particularly, how literary language finds itself at a loss. But like the melancholic’s recuperation of the lost object through constant speaking about it, the text offers a recuperation of the object while **bemoaning the inadequacy of language**. There are a number of self-reflexive examples in the text: the biographer’s professed inability to convey his subject, Orlando’s frustrated inability to describe Sasha, the failure of language to match Nature, the rendering of Orlando’s change into a woman as indescribable, and Shelmerdine and Orlando’s love which is described as inexpressible” (68).

“Woolf demonstrates the doubleness of language; she laments its inadequacy while effectively and fantastically achieving her ends. At the same time, she stages the loss of Vita while simultaneously producing her” (69).

1.10 Gilmore, Lois J.

"The Orlando project: claiming Woolf for the community college." Virginia Woolf Miscellany, no. 73, 2008, p. 13+. Literature Resource Center, go.galegroup.com.ezproxy.gc.cuny.edu/ps/i.do?p=GLS\sw=w\u=cuny_gradctr\v=2.1\it=r\id=GAL

Appendix A-Handouts

Project Part I. Preliminary Questionnaire

1\.. If you have read any of Virginia Woolf's writings, identify them and explain the context. For example, did you read them for a class? For pleasure? 2\.. If you have previously heard of Virginia Woolf or any of her writing but have not specifically read any of her work, please explain when and where you have heard of her prior to this class. 3\.. Identify any Alms you have seen that are related to Virginia Woolf's writings. 4\.. Please explain your reading experiences. Have you ever been "engrossed" in a novel? If so, what elements helped you enter the world of the novel? 5\.. What have been your best experiences studying the novel in the classroom? What elements help you understand and "appreciate" the novel?

Part II. Reading/Discussion Guide

Chapter One 1\.. At what time period does the novel begin? What are the historical events that situate the novel? Who are the historical personages Orlando meets? 2\.. Identify the narrative "voice." 3\.. What do we learn about Orlando? How? 4\.. What does the biographer say about constructing Orlando's identity? Why is it so important for the biographer to define Orlando? 5\.. Identify the major themes introduced in this chapter. How does the narrative voice introduce these themes? 6\.. What do you think will be the major symbols in the novel? 7\.. What can you say about yourself-the reader-in relationship to the novel at this point? What does Woolf do to draw you into the life and history of Orlando?

Chapter Two 1\.. What changes does Orlando undergo? Why? How does the biographer explain these changes? 2\.. Why is Orlando "done with men"? 3\.. Identify the focal points of this chapter. What details are repeated? What details/symbols do you consider most significant? 4\.. How does the theme of gender manifest in this chapter? 5\.. In what activities does Orlando engage? How would you describe Orlando in this chapter? 6\.. What are the biographer's problems and/or issues?

Chapter Three 1\.. Identify the historical time period in this chapter. 2\.. What is Orlando doing in this chapter? How would you describe Orlando in this chapter? 3\.. What is Orlando's stance toward empire? Of what importance are "place" and "geography"? 4\.. What is the biographer dealing with in this chapter? 5\.. How does clothing figure in this chapter? 6\.. What changes come about for Orlando? How? What do you think about this change? 7\.. Speculate at to what this change will mean for Orlando.

Chapter Four 1\.. What changes has her "gender" wrought on Orlando? How would you describe her? Can you identify some gender conflicts? How is your notion of gender challenged? 2\.. Has Orlando's gender changed

her relationship to history? To place? 3\. Trace the theme of "writing" in this chapter. What writers does Orlando meet? What is their attitude toward Orlando? 4\. What difference does the return to England make? Why is the setting so important? 5\. In what ways does travel figure in the novel? 6\. Explain how the name of the ship *Enamoured Lady* illustrates the comic/ironic aspects of the novel. Can you think of any other instances?

Chapter Five 1\. What changes occur in this chapter? 2\. Identify the historical period of this chapter. 3\. How would you describe Orlando? 4\. What loose ends are tied up? 5\. What does the biographer say about Orlando's life? 6\. How does the romantic scenario play out in traditional and non-traditional ways? 7\. What are some of the ironies of this chapter? 8\. As a reader explain your relationship to the text and to Orlando.

Chapter Six 1\. Identify the historical time period, and identify some ironies associated with the disruption of the reader's traditional expectations for the novel like plot, character, setting, theme 2\. Do any of the details and symbols you identified as significant in question 6, Chapter One, show up in this chapter? If so, what is the importance? 3\. What issues is the biographer dealing with in this "final" chapter? 4\. Explain how the plot is resolved. 5\. In what ways is Orlando the same? In what ways is he/she different? What are the differences in the ways men and women relate to time and place? How are these gender issues resolved? 6\. On what day and time does the novel "end"?

Part III. Group Projects

The purpose of this assignment is to add depth and perspective to our study of Virginia Woolf's novel *Orlando*. There are two components to the Part III assignments: 1\. a written analysis of findings, a portfolio of material, and a bibliographic list of sources; 2\. a brief (5-10 minute) presentation of your findings. Each group should work together to clarify the purpose, design of the project, and divide the tasks. The final project will be submitted and graded as a group project. The oral component may be assigned to a single member of the group, and it must be given to the class on the designated date.

Choose one of the following topics:

1\. Significance of Place: Investigate the various locations prominent in the novel and how they relate to plot or character.

2\. Fact and Fiction: Fact, as Woolf shows, is an utterly subjective quality. What is unable to be proven by letters and documents may certainly still be fact. And what seems to be completely objective, like the dates of birth and death, is entirely arbitrary. Investigate the construction of fact and fiction in the novel.

3\. Gender & Representation: Investigate the ways in which clothing constructs identity, gender, and power. How do the details of ordinary reality and physical appearance construct identity and truth? What other elements construct identity?

4\. Spectacles of Empire & Power: Investigate the historical pageants like the Great Frost, the visits of Queen Elizabeth I, the relationship between Britain & Turkey, World War I.